STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

Proposed National Security Strategy Framework

Ireland's First Comprehensive Security Architecture

Security Ireland 2026

IDEA IN BRIEF

THE GAP
Ireland is one of the few EU states without a published National Security Strategy. It is chairing the Council of the EU during the largest defence spending programme in European history, operationalising bilateral security cooperation with the UK for the first time, and attempting to transform a defence establishment at a fifty-year low — all without a document that explains how these decisions relate to each other. Each is being made in isolation. This paper provides the connective tissue.

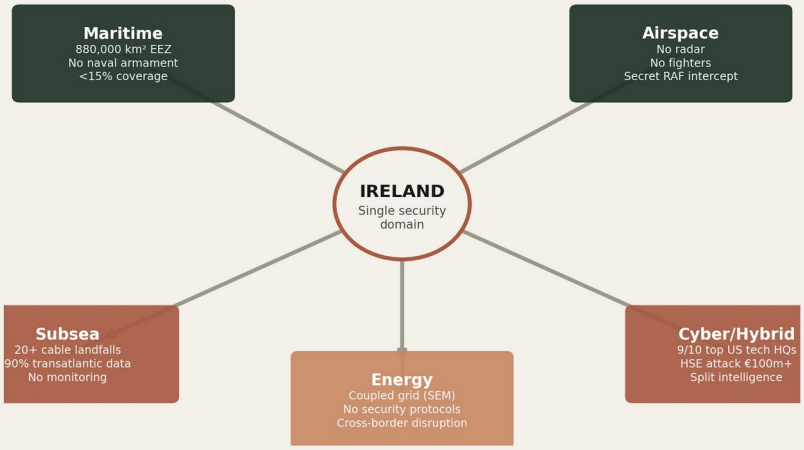
THE FRAMEWORK
A national security strategy must do five things: assess the threat environment honestly, define capability requirements, design the institutional architecture to deliver them, identify the funding model, and specify the cooperation frameworks that extend domestic capacity. This paper does all five — connected as a single system.

THE POSITION
Ireland is militarily non-aligned but not neutral to threats. Non-alignment, properly understood, requires more security capability, not less, because a non-aligned state cannot rely on alliance guarantees. Switzerland, Austria, and Finland understood this. Yet Ireland is today's exception: a state whose non-alignment has justified the absence of the capability non-alignment demands. This strategy corrects the inversion.

0.2% of GDP	880,000 km²	€42bn	7,531
Defence spending — lowest in EU	EEZ — one of Europe's largest	Surplus 2022–2024	Personnel (50-year low)

The Five Threat Domains

Five dimensions of a single security domain. None hypothetical — each has produced incidents in the past three years.



Source: Author's analysis. Commission on Defence Forces (2022), Dept of Defence, Cork Summit (Mar 2026).

Figure 1: The five threat domains. Five dimensions of a single security domain defined by the island and its maritime approaches. None hypothetical — each has produced incidents in the past three years.

Part I: The Threat Assessment

Ireland is not safe by accident, it is safe by dependency. Ireland's security has rested on three pillars: (1) invisible threats the public did not perceive, (2) no external pressure to contribute, and (3) a United Kingdom willing to provide a security umbrella without acknowledgement. All three pillars have degraded simultaneously.

Maritime

Ireland's Exclusive Economic Zone covers 880,000 km² of the northeast Atlantic — one of Europe's largest and Russian submarine activity has increased since 2014. The Naval Service operates nine vessels with no functioning armament and can deploy one large vessel at any time. It has no anti-submarine capability; the UK Royal Navy provides the de facto maritime umbrella with no treaty basis. Surveillance coverage on any given day is estimated at less than 15%.

Airspace

Ireland has no primary radar, no fighter aircraft, no surface-to-air missiles. Under a secret arrangement, the RAF intercepts hostile aircraft — sometimes without prior Irish awareness. Russian military aircraft have been intercepted over Ireland without Irish authorities being initially aware. The airspace is operationally continuous: a radar gap over Ireland degrades situational awareness for the island as a whole.

Subsea Infrastructure

Over twenty submarine cables make landfall on Irish shores, carrying over 90% of transatlantic data traffic. The Celtic Interconnector to France arrives 2027; and the Far North Fiber to Alaska, Japan, and Norway is planned for 2026. Ireland is becoming more critical, not less. The Nord Stream sabotage demonstrated that subsea infrastructure is a domain of active hybrid threat. Ireland has no monitoring capability.

Cyber and Hybrid

Nine of ten top US tech firms have their EU headquarters in Ireland. A cyber attack on Irish-hosted systems affects the entire Union. The 2021 HSE ransomware attack cost hundreds of millions. During President Zelensky's December 2025 visit, drones were detected 17 km offshore; Portugal's GNR provided counter-drone defence near Leinster House. Six months before the Presidency, Ireland

could not secure its own capital without foreign military assistance.

Energy

The island's energy grid operates as a coupled system through the Single Electricity Market. Interconnectors link Ireland to Great Britain, however grid balancing does not respect the border: no joint security protocols exist. Disruption propagates cross-border in real time.

WHAT THE THREAT ASSESSMENT MEANS

These are not five separate problems, they are five dimensions of a single security domain that is geographically defined by the island and its maritime approaches, and that is institutionally undefended. The dependency on the UK for basic security — airspace intercept, maritime patrol, intelligence — is not stable. Brexit introduced friction, and British priorities are shifting to the Indo-Pacific. The RAF's cover is a courtesy, not a treaty obligation. As allegiences are being redrawn, it is clear that courtesies can be withdrawn.

Part II: Capability Requirements

The threat assessment defines the capability requirements: Ireland does not need to match British or French military capability, it merely needs to perform four functions:

1. Monitor its own domain. See what is in its airspace, on its seas, under its waters, and in its digital infrastructure. This is the minimum condition for sovereignty; a state that cannot see what is happening in its own territory is outsourcing sovereignty.

2. Respond to sub-threshold incidents. Counter-drone, cyber incident response, cable coordination, energy infrastructure protection: these are the actual threats, none of which requires a standing army of 50,000. But they all require institutional capacity that Ireland currently lacks.

3. Contribute in its geographic domains. Maritime surveillance, subsea protection, cyber resilience: Ireland does not need main battle tanks, it just needs to contribute where its geography makes its contribution irreplaceable.

4. Sustain capability over time. Recruit and retain personnel, maintain equipment, build procurement expertise, and develop intelligence architecture. This is the institutional dimension spending alone cannot provide.

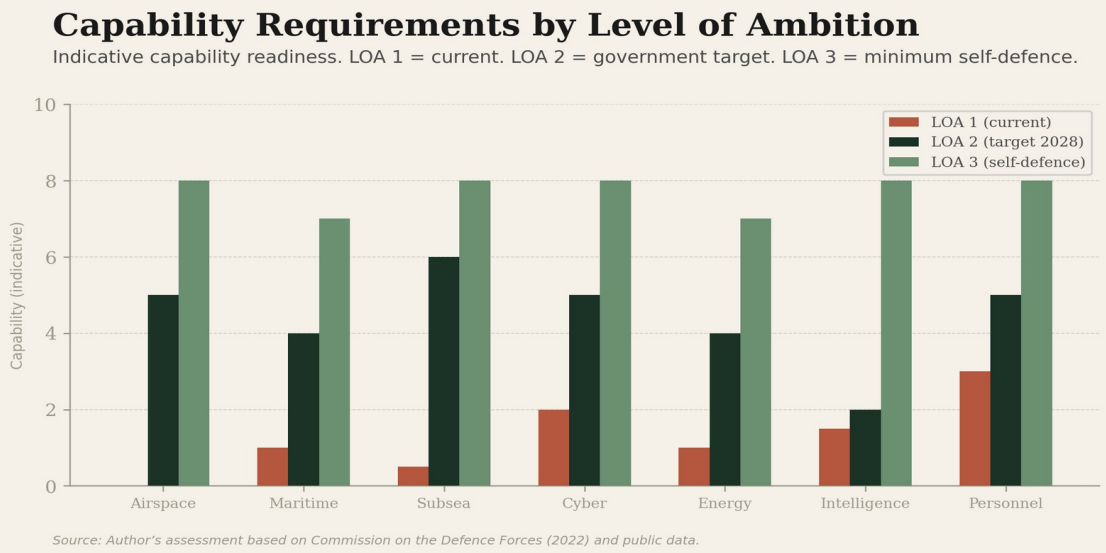


Figure 2: Capability requirements by Level of Ambition. LOA 1 (current) — inadequate. LOA 2 (target 2028) — monitoring capability. LOA 3 — minimum for self-defence.

Domain	Monitor (LOA 2)	Respond (LOA 2)	Contribute (EU/bilateral)	Sustain
Airspace	Primary radar (2028)	Counter-drone (2026)	Air domain data (Cork MoU)	Operators; maintenance
Maritime	CISE data; patrol	Armed vessels; ASW	PESCO Maritime; Atlantic node	Naval personnel
Subsea	CISE; bilateral	Cable incident protocols	PESCO Seabed; North Sea Decl.	Coordination capacity
Cyber	NCSC strengthening	Incident response; exercise	PESCO Cyber; Hybrid Toolbox	Clearances; workforce
Energy	Joint monitoring	Coordinated response	SEM security annex	Cross-border coord.
Intelligence	Unified assessment	All-source fusion	Bilateral sharing; ITPP	Legislative reform

Source: Author's analysis. Commission on Defence Forces (2022), Cork MoU, PESCO documentation.

Part III: Institutional Architecture

Ireland ran a €42 billion surplus between 2022 and 2024. It could fund LOA 3 from a single year's surplus, meaning that the constraint is not money but institutional bandwidth: the distance between what the system can coordinate and what the security environment demands. Ireland's system has been architecturally configured for the absence of military capability since the Civil War and the disbandment of the National Army in 1923.

1. National Security Council

Ireland's National Security Committee exists but lacks institutional weight. This strategy proposes a National Security Council chaired by the Taoiseach with statutory authority over threat assessment, capability planning, and interagency coordination. The NSC is the institutional home for this strategy — the body responsible for its implementation and review.

2. Unified Intelligence

Ireland's intelligence is split between J2/IMIS (military), Garda CSB (police), and NCSC (cyber) — unique in Europe. Every comparable state has unified intelligence. Without fused threat assessment, every system — radar, maritime surveillance, cyber — operates in isolation. Intelligence reform is the prerequisite for everything else.

3. Transformed Procurement

Ireland's procurement has managed routine replacement, but it is now delivering primary radar, counter-drone, naval armament, and armoured vehicles — capabilities nobody in the system has operated. This requires dedicated programme management, external technical expertise, and integration planning for systems that do not yet exist.

4. Competitive Personnel Architecture

7,531 against 9,739 establishment means Ireland is at a fifty-year low. Not helping is that a Private 3 Star salary is €40,000 where rent near barracks exceeds €1,800/month. This strategy proposes targeted compensation reform for specialist technical roles, housing support linked to barracks locations, and a reformed reserve drawing on civilian expertise.

5. Defence Industrial Policy

Ireland has €2.5 billion in emerging procurement demand and no industrial policy. This strategy establishes that Ireland's contribution is domain-specific: cyber, maritime sensing, AI, and dual-use technology. The institutional prerequisites — security clearances, classified information handling, Enterprise Ireland engagement, export controls — must be built in parallel with the procurement pipeline.

Part IV: The Funding Model

Ireland's defence funding flows through five channels. This strategy connects them as a single architecture.

National budget: €1.7 billion capital programme 2026–2030. Funds radar, naval, counter-drone, vehicles, personnel. This strategy proposes a statutory defence investment floor — percentage of GNI*, not GDP — that insulates the programme from annual budget politics.

EU instruments: SAFE (€150bn loans), EDIP (€1.5bn grants), EDF (€8bn R&D). The Presidency determines whether Ireland can access these. The four Presidency Desk briefs are designed to ensure the rules recognise domain-specific contribution.

Bilateral UK–Ireland: Cork MoU enables joint procurement, government-to-government sales, personnel exchanges. This strategy treats bilateral cooperation as an efficiency multiplier.

NATO-adjacent: ITPP, North Sea Declaration. Standards, exercises, intelligence access. Non-aligned but networked — the Swiss model.

CISE and data: Maritime surveillance sharing. Ireland as data provider (Atlantic node), not consumer.

THE PERMANENT FINANCING QUESTION

Unlike Germany's constitutional debt brake reform, Ireland has no structural mechanism insulating defence investment from annual budget politics. This strategy proposes that a statutory defence investment floor — expressed as a percentage of GNI* rather than GDP, to account for Ireland's distorted national accounts — be legislated as part of the strategy's implementation. GNI* is the CSO's adjusted measure of actual national income. A floor pegged to GNI* would be analytically honest and practically enforceable.

Part V: The Cooperation Architecture

Ireland's security cannot be delivered domestically alone. The strategy operates through three cooperation tracks that feed into each other:

One: Domestic capability is the foundation.

Two: Bilateral cooperation extends it.

Three: EU frameworks institutionalise it.

This is the strategy's central structural insight: the three tracks are not alternatives, they are layers of a single architecture.

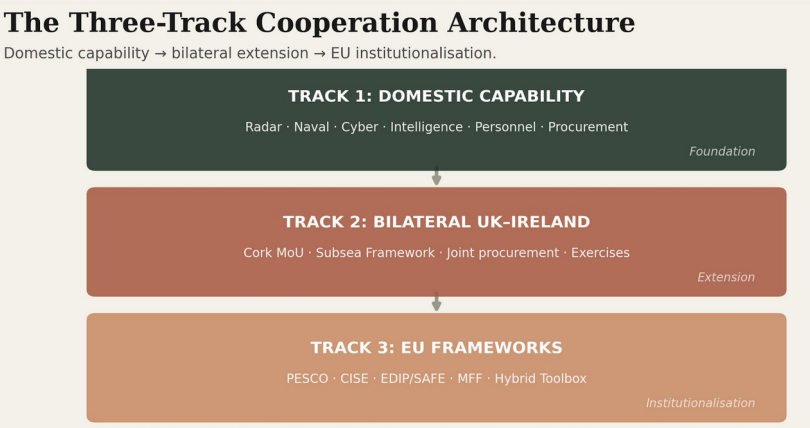


Figure 3: The three-track cooperation architecture. Domestic capability → bilateral extension → EU institutionalisation. Each layer builds on the one before it. The bilateral track builds the institutional capacity that makes the EU track credible.

Track 1 Domestic: Build the institutional infrastructure — radar, naval, cyber, intelligence, personnel, procurement — that gives Ireland

something to contribute. Without domestic capacity, cooperation frameworks are empty.

Track 2 — Bilateral: Extend domestic capacity into the shared UK–Ireland security domain. Joint procurement, exercises, intelligence-sharing. Demonstrates to EU partners that Ireland generates real capability.

Track 3 — EU: Institutionalise Ireland's contribution within EU governance and funding. PESCO formalises the contribution. EDIP/SAFE fund it. The MFF makes it permanent. The Presidency locks it in.

Part VI: Implementation

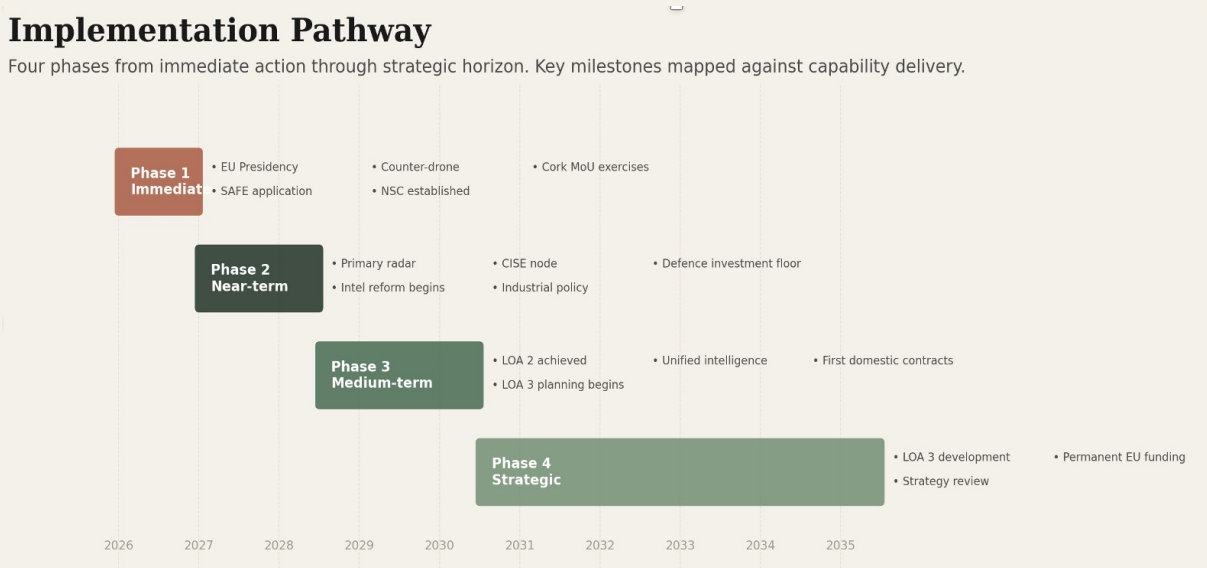


Figure 4: Implementation pathway. Four phases from immediate (2026) through strategic horizon (2030–2035). Key milestones mapped against capability delivery.

Phase 1: Immediate (2026)

Publish this strategy. Establish the National Security Council. Complete counter-drone procurement. Execute the four Presidency Desk briefs. Begin UK live exercises (September). Apply for SAFE loans.

Phase 2: Near-term (2027–2028)

Deliver primary radar. Achieve CISE node operational capability. Legislate statutory defence investment floor. Begin intelligence unification. Implement defence industrial policy. Commission first new-build naval vessel.

Phase 3: Medium-term (2028–2030)

Achieve LOA 2 across all domains. Unified intelligence agency operational. First domestic cyber/maritime sensing contracts within EU frameworks. Begin LOA 3 planning.

Phase 4: Strategic horizon (2030–2035)

LOA 3 capability development. Permanent EU funding pathways operational. Mature defence industrial participation. Intelligence fully integrated with partners. Strategy review and update.

WHAT HAPPENS IF THIS STRATEGY IS NOT ADOPTED

Ireland continues making consequential decisions in isolation. The Cork MoU, the radar programme, the counter-drone procurement, the Presidency briefs, the PESCO projects — each proceeds without a framework explaining how they relate. The €1.7 billion programme produces equipment without the institutional architecture to convert it into capability; the EU Presidency passes without locking in Ireland's permanent role. And Ireland's security continues to rest on a dependency it cannot acknowledge, provided by a partner it defined itself in opposition to, under an arrangement that has no treaty basis. This is not a stable architecture.

A NOTE ON METHOD

This framework synthesises publicly available information from Security Ireland's published research programme. The threat assessment draws on open-source reporting, the Commission on Defence Forces (2022), European Defence Agency data, and government statements. Capability requirements derive from the LOA framework. The institutional analysis builds on the coordination architecture framework developed across the series. Cooperation frameworks draw on the Presidency Desk briefs and the UK–Ireland working papers. This is a proposed framework. It is designed to be adopted, adapted, or contested — but it is designed to exist. Ireland's most consequential security gap is not a missing radar or an unarmed frigate, it is the absence of a document that explains what the state is trying to build, why, and how.

Series Context

This is the foundational document in the Security Ireland research programme. Every other paper on the *For Policymakers* page — the diagnostic research papers, the domestic capability frameworks, the bilateral working papers, the Presidency Desk briefs — is a chapter of this document. This is the spine.

Companion papers: Ireland's Defense Problem Isn't Neutrality; Europe's Defense Problem Isn't Spending; Ireland's Defence & Security Spending; The UK–Ireland Security Interface; The GFA and the Security Gap; the Presidency Desk series; Building the Institutional Infrastructure; The LOA Transition Architecture; Ireland's Defence Industrial Architecture.

Security ***Ireland***

Independent analysis for a changing Ireland. · securityireland.ie